

THE FRIENDS WITH FOUR KEYS: COLD OPEN, FABLE v0.3

2026-08-31. The same blind Fable agent's revision of its v0.2 against the six reader notes (four-keys-cold-open-reader-check-2026-08-31.md). Fable remains blind to Parts A to F: it does not know which of the four, what was behind the door, or that anyone is alive. Title options at the foot, Stephen-requested.

Checks: 330 words (pass, at the cap) · no em dashes (pass) · nothing invented (pass; the solicitor detail dropped, which is a cut not an addition) · voice notes: "bottom of her stairs", "in her handwriting", "Nobody's on this show without saying yes first, and you'll hear them say it" (all three odd phrasings replaced) · the four established as "the four people she loved most in the world" before the accusation lands · the Saturday carries the ring-round, nobody-goes-alone and the first-day-all-four-could logic; it stays the Saturday, per the spine's swap window · Kestrel Head established in one clause · her trade is signs, not letters · sign-off is the readers' example, tightened.

Timing: 2:12 at 150 wpm · 2:21 at 140 · 2:32 at 130. The death lands in the first sentence; the keys at about 0:20.

Structure note: the show ident has moved from the top to the sign-off, so the open starts on Violet. Faster into the death; flag if the ident-first convention matters.

Nine months ago, Violet Moore died at the bottom of her stairs. She was forty-four. She painted signs all over this city, shopfronts, boat names, once the side of a bus. The coroner called it an accident.

Two weeks later, four people got a key in the post, and a letter in her handwriting. Liam Bryce. Ruby Walker. Margo Rivera. Brad Collins. The four people she loved most in the world.

The letter said she thought one of them was planning to kill her. She didn't know which, and might be wrong. She told them not to go to the police, and why. What she'd found was behind a door only the four of them could open.

They rang each other that night and agreed nobody would go alone. The first day all four could stand at that door together was the Saturday. Behind it, a second letter. This one said she knew. Beside it, something of hers. The two still living won't say what.

Seven weeks after the funeral, Brad Collins drove to Kestrel Head, the place people here go when they don't mean to come back. He was never found. Five months on, Margo Rivera's car was in the same car park. Her body came into the harbour three days later.

Liam and Ruby each went to the police within the week. Not to accuse. To say: I am frightened of him. I am frightened of her. A sergeant I trust in Harbor Ward tells me they looked, properly. The letters are really hers, and they found nothing.

Now those two are taking each other apart in the Gazette, over a dead woman's letter. I wasn't there for any of it. Ruby's agreed to talk. Liam hasn't, yet. Nobody's on this show without saying yes first, and you'll hear them say it.

I can't promise answers. But I keep coming back to those keys.

This is Echoes of Havenbay, I'm Ally Quinn. Goodnight for now, Harbour. Sleep tight.

330 words.

The title: RULED, Stephen, 2026-08-31

The Friends with Four Keys. Stephen's own, not one of the eight. Registered warm on purpose: the thesis word is friends, the image is the keys, and the twist is untouched. The eight below are kept as the record of the option pass.

Title options (Fable's eight, superseded by the ruling)

1. Four Keys
2. One of You
3. The Second Letter
4. Behind the Door
5. She Might Be Wrong
6. What Violet Knew
7. The Ones She Loved Most
8. Afraid of Each Other